THE BOOK OF WAR

Every day at dawn, an hour before sunrise, the musicians of the naqqar khana would begin to play a few tentative melodies to wake up the residents of Fatehpur Sikri. An hour later, just after sunrise, the music began in earnest and an hour-long medley of tunes and refrains were played, which included the lusty use of cymbals and the deep bass of the large naqqara drums. Following the musical performance there was a reading of poems and ‘beautiful sentences’, again lasting an hour, and finally the residents of the city and palace were ready to face a new day. The Jesuit priests who were present at this time left a less than glowing record of these musical mornings. ‘At fixed hours, namely before dawn when the cocks begin to crow…a barbaric din is kept up for the space of a full hour by means of trumpets, bugles, drums, rattles, bells and the like’. The Jesuits would have had ample opportunity to moan about the quality of the naqqara music, for the band now played according to the Hindustani system of dividing the day into eight watches, or ‘ghari’. Their assessment was all the more galling as many of the tunes performed by the naqqar khana had been composed by Akbar himself, more than 200 in the style of old Khwarizmian songs. In fact, it may have even been the Padshah himself playing as Abu’l Fazl tells us that he was ‘likewise an excellent hand in performing, especially on the naqqara’.

After spending some time in personal prayers, Akbar would then appear at a balcony, where an assembled crowd below the window was waiting to catch a glimpse, or darshan, of the emperor before beginning their day. The jharoka darshan would become one of the enduring symbols of Mughal authority and Abu’l Fazl described how the Padshah ‘is visible from outside the awning to people of all ranks, whether they be given to worldly pursuits, or to a life of solitary contemplation, without any molestation from the mace-bearers. This mode of showing himself is called, in the language of the country, darshan, and it frequently happens that business is transacted at this time.’ The power of this symbol, transcending all religion, may be seen in the fact that centuries later in 1911, the king and queen of a new empire